



Niwas. Inside the high walls, only the gray drabness of the official extensions of the original building and the few staff who hang around announce power. It is early evening and you are waiting for him in a room whose only adornments are James Fergusson's line drawings of the Sun Temple of Konark and the Lingaraj Temple in Bhubaneswar on the wall. And the writers on the shelf are an eclectic lot, among them John le Carre, Paul Scott, Che Guevara, John Simpson, Alex Hailey, Anne Rice, Wilbur Smith, Tom Clancy....

As you are being led to the man himself, you can't miss the benevolent gaze of Patnaik pere, framed and garlanded, from the verandah. He is at the head of a con-

ON THE VIOLENCE

“It is the most regrettable thing that has happened in the 11 years of my public life. But I will resolve it.”

“In the eight-and-a-half years that I have been the CM, there were only two communal incidents.”

ference table, and on his left, armed with files, is his principal secretary. Behind him, on the wall, is the protective figure of the father, who in his lifetime was revered in the state as patriarch, patriot, and adventurer. Are you in face-to-face with a chief minister who failed his duty to save the lives of Christians and others in the tribal-dominated district of Kandhamal? Or, are you in the company of one of India's smartest politicians who defy conventional laws of politics? Or, are you being given access to the mind of an accidental politician who continues to be astonished by his own progress through the dirty by-